

ASCII MASTER FLOW – PANEL 1/22: The control question and the four versions

PHILOSOPHY PAPER 11 – PHILOSOPHY OF RELIGION 03

PROBLEM OF EVIL

COMPLETE TOPIC ASCII MASTER FLOW DIAGRAM – 22 PANELS

Syllabus, verbatim: "Problem of Evil."

Read top to bottom. Each panel is data-complete: premises, named critics, replies and verdict.

EVIL EXISTS. SO WHAT EXACTLY FOLLOWS?

+-----+-----+-----+-----+			
LOGICAL	EVIDENTIAL	EXISTENTIAL	DISTRIBUTIONAL
Mackie 1955	Rowe 1979	Adams 1999	karma traditions
"the set is inconsistent"	"gratuitous evil makes God improbable"	"is THIS life a great good TO THIS PERSON?"	"why THIS person rather than that one?"
BURDEN: show a POSSIBLE morally sufficient reason	BURDEN: restore PROBABILITY	BURDEN: DEFEAT within the individual life	BURDEN: explain ALLOCATION
REPLY-TYPE: DEFENCE	REPLY-TYPE: THEODICY or SKEPTICAL THEISM	REPLY-TYPE: goodness TO PERSONS	REPLY-TYPE: karma; the West has no standard one

MISMATCH = ERROR. Answering Mackie with Plantinga is correct.

Answering Rowe with Plantinga is a version error and loses marks.

FULL DIVINE PROFILE UNDER TEST: omnipotent + omniscient + perfectly good + creator.

Omniscience is not in Mackie's three propositions but blocks "God did not notice".

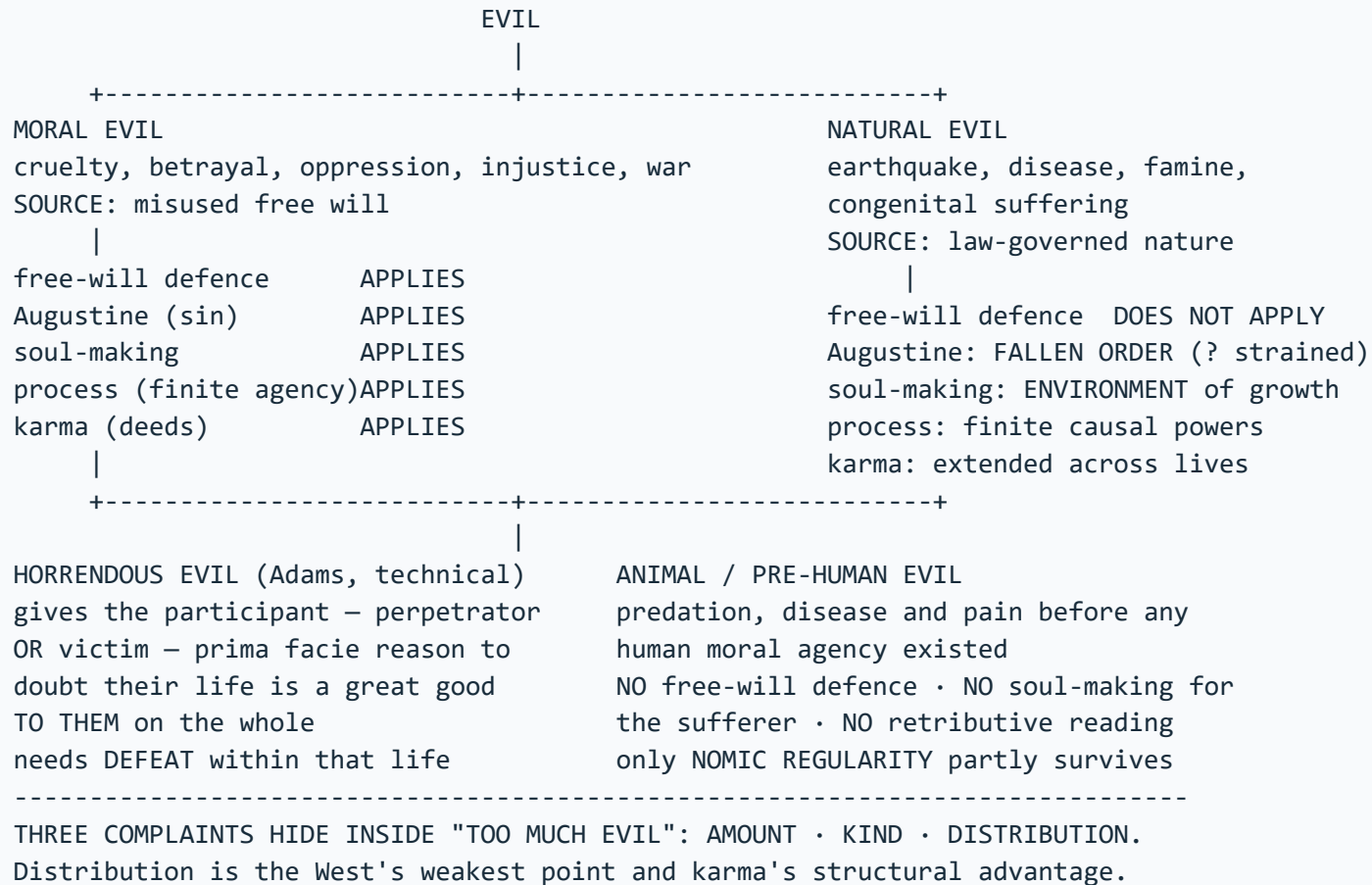
ASCII MASTER FLOW – PANEL 2/22: Defence, theodicy, revision, dissolution

FOUR THINGS A REPLY TO EVIL CAN BE – DO NOT MERGE THEM

DEFENCE	God COULD have a morally sufficient reason Plantinga; Wykstra	success = bare LOGICAL POSSIBILITY; refuted only by showing the story is impossible
THEODICY	This IS God's actual reason Augustine, Hick, Leibniz, process theodicy	success = plausibility + truth; refuted if the reason is false or insufficient
REVISION	change the God-concept so the charge lapses	process/finite God: goodness kept, omnipotence surrendered
DISSOLUTION	remove the defendant altogether	Buddhism, Jainism, Mimamsa, karma without a creator

STANDING RULE: a theodicy is NOT REFUTED by its cost – it is MEASURED by it.
 ETHICS CONTROL: causal explanation is never moral permission to withhold aid.
 Pastoral care and philosophical argument answer different questions; do not fuse them.

ASCII MASTER FLOW – PANEL 3/22: Kinds of evil and the scope of every reply



ASCII MASTER FLOW – PANEL 4/22: The classical dilemma and its true provenance

THE FOUR-HORN DILEMMA

IS GOD WILLING TO PREVENT EVIL BUT NOT ABLE? -> then not omnipotent
IS GOD ABLE BUT NOT WILLING? -> then not perfectly good
IS GOD NEITHER ABLE NOR WILLING? -> then why call this God?
IS GOD BOTH ABLE AND WILLING? -> then whence evil?

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PROVENANCE – EXAMINABLE, AND USUALLY GOT WRONG

? traditionally ascribed to EPICURUS

! transmitted through LACTANTIUS, De Ira Dei 13 (early 4th century CE)

! NO SURVIVING EPICUREAN TEXT CONTAINS IT

SAFE FORM: "the dilemma transmitted by Lactantius and traditionally ascribed to Epicurus"

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LIMIT: the dilemma is rhetorically powerful and LOGICALLY INCOMPLETE.

It presupposes exactly the bridging premises of Panel 5, which it never states.

Quoting it without those premises produces a lament rather than an argument.

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OTHER QUOTATION CONTROLS FOR THIS CLAUSE

"vale of Soul-making" -> JOHN KEATS, letter to George and Georgiana Keats,
spring 1819; adopted by HICK, not coined by him

"defeat" (vs balancing off) -> CHISHOLM's term, used by ADAMS

"fellow-sufferer who understands" -> WHITEHEAD, Process and Reality, final chapter

CORNEA -> WYKSTRA 1984

"All evil is either sin or punishment for sin" -> Augustinian doctrine; the printed 2023
stem is the object of analysis, ? not a certified
verbatim translation

ASCII MASTER FLOW – PANEL 5/22: Mackie's logical problem and the two bridges

J. L. MACKIE, "Evil and Omnipotence", MIND (1955)

THE SET AS USUALLY PRINTED

- (1) God is omnipotent
- (2) God is perfectly good
- (3) Evil exists

-> NOT a formal contradiction:
nothing in (1)-(3) plus logic
alone entails p and not-p

THE SET AS IT MUST BE WRITTEN

- (1) God is omnipotent
- (2) God is omniscient
- (3) God is perfectly good
- (4) Evil exists

+ BRIDGE A (goodness): a perfectly good being
eliminates every evil it can, unless it has
a morally sufficient reason
+ BRIDGE B (power): an omnipotent being has no
relevant limit on preventing any evil whose
prevention is logically possible
-> NOW the set is inconsistent

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MACKIE'S OWN TAXONOMY

ADEQUATE SOLUTIONS honestly abandon one of the propositions

FALLACIOUS SOLUTIONS appear to keep all three while covertly limiting power or
redefining goodness – e.g. "good cannot exist without evil",
"evil is a necessary means to good", "the universe is better
with some evil", "evil is due to human free will"

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THE THEIST'S THREE EXITS – EACH DENIES SOMETHING

deny BRIDGE A -> insert "unless there is a morally sufficient reason"
-> the entire space of DEFENCES and THEODICIES opens

deny BRIDGE B -> Plantinga (God cannot causally determine free rightness) or
process theism (classical omnipotence rejected outright)

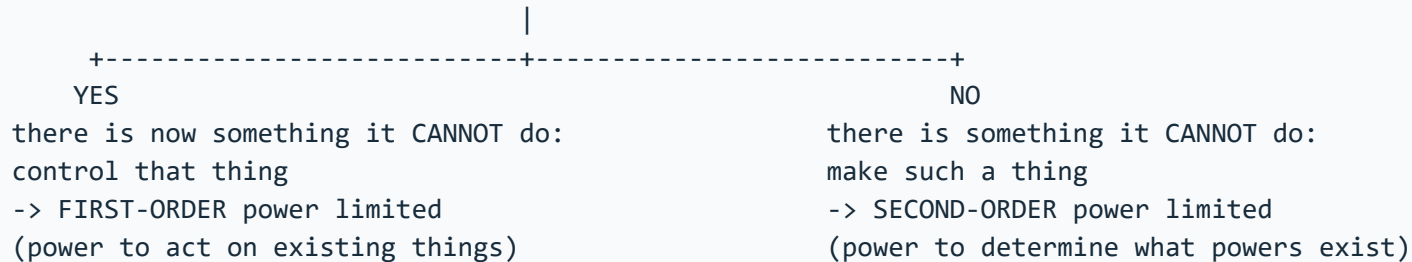
deny (4)'s force -> privation (Augustine) or the empirical level (Advaita)
COST: the seriousness of suffering

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VERDICT: the logical problem is widely regarded as ANSWERED. The live debate has
MIGRATED to Rowe's evidential form, where consistency no longer suffices.

ASCII MASTER FLOW – PANEL 6/22: The paradox of omnipotence (2021 Q5(e), 10 marks)

CAN AN OMNIPOTENT BEING CREATE A THING IT CANNOT AFTERWARDS CONTROL?



MACKIE: unrestricted omnipotence in BOTH senses is incoherent.

- THREE RESTRICTIONS THAT DISSOLVE IT, WITH THEIR COSTS
- | | |
|-------------------------|---|
| (a) LOGICAL-POSSIBILITY | omnipotence covers only the logically possible
COST: modest, near-universally conceded; but it does not
settle whether "free agents who never go wrong" is
actualizable by God |
| (b) SELF-BINDING | second-order sovereignty exercised IN creating free agents
COST: restraint becomes VOLUNTARY, re-opening the question
why God does not intervene in the worst cases |
| (c) ABANDONMENT | process theism drops classical omnipotence
COST: no guarantee of any final victory over evil |

LINK TO EVIL – THE STEM'S CONTEXT CLAUSE IS MANDATORY
the FREE-WILL DEFENCE REQUIRES (a) or (b): God creates significantly free agents and
cannot causally guarantee that they choose well.
PLANTINGA: God CHOOSES not to override. GRIFFIN: God CANNOT coerce.
VERDICT: the paradox does not refute theism; it forces theism to SPECIFY which sense
of omnipotence it defends, and to pay for the choice.
BOUNDARY: the attribute's independent coherence belongs to Notions of God.

ASCII MASTER FLOW – PANEL 7/22: Plantinga's free-will defence and transworld depravity

ALVIN PLANTINGA, God, Freedom, and Evil (1974) – A DEFENCE, NOT A THEODICY

- (1) A world with significantly free creatures is more valuable, other things equal, than a world with no free creatures at all.
- (2) Significant freedom entails genuinely available alternatives: an agent free with respect to an action can perform it or refrain.
- (3) God cannot CAUSALLY DETERMINE a creature to FREELY do only what is right – that description cancels itself.
- (4) Therefore God can create free persons only by accepting the POSSIBILITY of misuse.
- (5) Therefore moral evil is COMPATIBLE with omnipotence and perfect goodness.

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MACKIE'S OBJECTION: why not create free agents who ALWAYS freely choose the good?
That is logically possible, so omnipotence covers it.

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REPLY – TRANSWORLD DEPRAVITY: it is POSSIBLE that every creaturely essence God could instantiate would go wrong in some circumstance. If so, a world of free agents who never go wrong was not available to God to actualize.

MODAL STATUS: POSSIBILITY ONLY. Plantinga never claims it is ACTUAL, and does not need to.
-> attacking it as "empirically unsupported" misses the modal point entirely.

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PRESUPPOSITION: libertarian freedom is coherent and sufficiently valuable.
A compatibilist denies premise (3) and rejects the defence at its root.
RESIDUE: NATURAL EVIL is untouched unless a further hypothesis is added.
ANSWER LINE: a world of programmed beneficence lacks the MORAL AUTHORSHIP of a world containing genuinely responsible agents.

ASCII MASTER FLOW – PANEL 8/22: Absolute creation and responsibility (2022 Q6(c), 15 marks)

THE STEM: "If God is the Absolute Creator, then the responsibility of the evil cannot belong to the human agent. Critically examine."

SCOPE FIX FIRST: the stem concerns MORAL evil and human agency.
Natural evil is the residue, not the subject.

THE STEM'S ARGUMENT

God creates everything – the agent, its powers, and the circumstances of its choice

therefore every act traces back to the creator

therefore human responsibility is an illusion

THE FOUR REPLIES

- (a) FREE-WILL DEFENCE: God creates the CAPACITY; the agent supplies the ACT. Authorship of the act is the agent's.
- (b) PRIVATION: God creates natures, not the defect in them; evil is a lack, not a created substance
- (c) FOREKNOWLEDGE IS NOT CAUSATION: knowing what will freely occur does not make it occur
- (d) PROCESS: rejects the ANTECEDENT – God does not have the unilateral power the stem assumes

RETAINED REJOINDER – CONCEDE IT, DO NOT SUPPRESS IT

knowingly choosing to instantiate the WHOLE SYSTEM, foreseeing its outcomes, remains MORALLY RELEVANT even if it is not causation.

VERDICT: the conditional is FALSE AS STATED – creaturely authorship survives – but it is NOT EMPTY: it correctly identifies a residual divine responsibility for the SYSTEM, which the free-will defence answers by PRICING rather than by DENYING.

ASCII MASTER FLOW – PANEL 9/22: Augustine – privation, sin and punishment (2023 Q8(a), 20 marks)

AUGUSTINE, Enchiridion and City of God – RECONSTRUCT BEFORE OBJECTING

- (1) Being, insofar as it is being, is GOOD.
 - (2) God creates BEINGS; God does not create evil substances.
 - (3) Corruption is PARASITIC: it depends on a good nature to corrupt.
 - (4) Moral fault is DISORDERED WILLING – the will turning from a greater to a lesser good.
- => EVIL = PRIVATION OF A DUE GOOD (privatio boni), not a rival creative principle.

THE 2023 THESIS: "all evil is either sin or the punishment for sin"

MORAL EVIL = SIN	NATURAL EVIL = PUNISHMENT
misuse of created freedom	a fallen, disordered order
the will's own defect	consequent on the Fall

CANONICAL EXAMPLE: rot is not a rival substance to wood; it is the loss of the wood's proper integrity. Blindness is a REAL lack in a creature whose nature calls for sight. -> PRIVATION DOES NOT MAKE PAIN IMAGINARY. This is the commonest misreading.

FOUR OBJECTIONS

- ! innocent suffering – infants and the congenitally afflicted fit punishment poorly
- ! animal and pre-human suffering – no choice, no sin, no growth
- ! privation is strained for intense POSITIVE pain, which does not feel like an absence
- ! INHERITED GUILT vs INHERITED CONDITION:
 - personal guilt for an ancestor's act -> morally the harder claim
 - inherited damaged condition + disordered social-natural order -> defensible, BUT still owes an account of why the condition and its unequal effects are permitted

COMPARATORS: HICK replaces PUNISHMENT with DEVELOPMENT; KARMA replaces a single FALL with a BEGINNINGLESS series and answers DISTRIBUTION, at the cost of verifiability. VERDICT: preserves divine goodness for moral evil; INCOMPLETE for natural, innocent and animal suffering.

ASCII MASTER FLOW – PANEL 10/22: Hick's Irenaean soul-making

JOHN HICK, Evil and the God of Love (1966)

- (1) Ready-made virtue is not ACHIEVED virtue.
- (2) Courage, compassion and trust require real difficulty, need and risk.
- (3) A world in which such virtues are possible must be LAW-GOVERNED and must therefore permit harmful consequences.
- (4) Humans are created IMMATURE, at an EPISTEMIC DISTANCE from God, so that faith and love are freely reached rather than compelled – the world is religiously ambiguous.
- (5) Therefore suffering can be the ENVIRONMENT of soul-making.

HICK'S OWN TYPOLOGY – ITSELF EXAMINABLE

+-----+	
AUGUSTINIAN TYPE	IRENAEAN TYPE
humanity created PERFECT	humanity created IMMATURE
FALL from that state	GROWTH toward LIKENESS
evil = privation + sin	evil = environment of growth
backward-looking, retributive	forward-looking, teleological
+-----+	

IRENÆUS supplies the IMAGE -> LIKENESS theology (2nd century).

ATTRIBUTION CHAIN – DO NOT COLLAPSE IT

KEATS coined "The vale of Soul-making" (journal-letter, spring 1819, preferred to "a vale of tears") · IRENÆUS supplies the THEOLOGY · HICK supplies the modern THEODICY

COVERAGE: moral AND natural evil – its advantage over the free-will defence.

COSTS: proportionality (much suffering builds nothing) · animals do not morally grow · the reply is a UNIVERSAL ESCHATOLOGICAL FULFILMENT resting on contested afterlife claims.

TRAP: "suffering makes us stronger" is NOT the theodicy. The three components are.

BOUNDARY: divine hiddenness as an independent argument belongs to Reason, Revelation and Faith; epistemic distance appears here only as a structural component.

ASCII MASTER FLOW – PANEL 11/22: Rowe's evidential problem and the inductive step

WILLIAM ROWE, "The Problem of Evil and Some Varieties of Atheism" (1979)

- (1) There exist instances of intense suffering that an omnipotent, omniscient being could have prevented without thereby losing some greater good or permitting some equally bad or worse evil.
- (2) An omniscient, wholly good being would prevent the occurrence of any intense suffering it could, unless it could not do so without losing some greater good or permitting some equally bad or worse evil.
- (3) Therefore there does not exist an omnipotent, omniscient, wholly good being.

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THE CANONICAL CASE – THE SUFFERING FAWN

a fawn trapped in a forest fire started by lightning, severely burned, lying in agony for days before dying; UNOBSERVED by any human; NO moral growth follows.

WHAT IT IS FOR: premise (1) – an EVIDENTIAL claim.

WHAT IT IS NOT: a deductive contradiction.

WHY BUILT THAT WAY: it removes free will, soul-making, desert and observer benefit from the case ALL AT ONCE.

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THE INDUCTIVE STEP – THE WHOLE BATTLEGROUND

"I can see no justifying reason for this evil."

-> "There is no justifying reason for this evil."

-> "Gratuitous evil exists."

-> "An omnipotent, wholly good God probably does not exist."

The step is an inference from IGNORANCE to ABSENCE. It is not automatically fallacious: we make such inferences correctly whenever we WOULD EXPECT to see the thing if it were there. Everything turns on whether a divine justifying reason is such a thing.

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THREE THEIST ROUTES

(a) attack the INFERENCE -> skeptical theism (Panel 12)

(b) supply a POSITIVE REASON -> theodicy (Panels 9, 10, 13)

(c) revise the GOD-CONCEPT -> process, finite God, non-creator systems

! (a) and (b) sit AWKWARDLY together: one says the reason is unknowable, the other names it. Noticing the tension earns marks.

Rowe claims EVIDENTIAL FORCE, not demonstration, and allows the theist may stay rational.

ASCII MASTER FLOW – PANEL 12/22: Skeptical theism, CORNEA and its price

PROPOSERS: STEPHEN WYKSTRA · WILLIAM ALSTON · MICHAEL BERGMANN · DANIEL HOWARD-SNYDER
IT IS A DEFENCE, NOT A THEODICY. IT TARGETS THE EVIDENTIAL, NOT THE LOGICAL, PROBLEM.

WYKSTRA'S CORNEA (1984) – Condition of Reasonable Epistemic Access

"It appears that p is absent" is a legitimate claim ONLY IF it is reasonable to believe that, given one's cognitive situation, p WOULD LIKELY BE DISCERNIBLE if it were there.

BERGMANN'S REPRESENTATIVENESS THESES

our sample of (i) possible GOODS, (ii) possible EVILS and (iii) the ENTAILMENT RELATIONS between them is NOT representative of the total space

THEREFORE the NOSEEUM inference – "no see 'um, so none there" – is UNWARRANTED for goods that would justify divine permission.

ANALOGIES

ALSTON : a novice examines a chess grandmaster's move, sees no point in it, and has no warrant to conclude there is none

WYKSTRA: an infant cannot see why a painful procedure is performed; that inability is no evidence that there is no reason

THREE STANDING COSTS

! MORAL SCEPTICISM (Almeida, Russell, Wielenberg): if we cannot judge an evil gratuitous, we equally cannot judge that we ought to PREVENT it – the duty to rescue is threatened. REPLY: obligation is fixed by what we KNOW. Critics: unstable.

! PARITY / DIVINE DECEPTION: the same scepticism undercuts divine promises and revelation. REPLY: restrict it to the value-entailment domain. Critics: ad hoc.

! BRACKETING: extended, no empirical evidence could ever count against theism – unfalsifiability is a cost even if it is not a refutation.

INDIAN PARITY: unseen moral potency (adrsta) is beyond the senses (atindriya), known only through testimony (sabda); the precise ripening of karma is among the Buddhist imponderables (acinteyya). Genuine parallel – and it inherits the SAME objection: a mechanism placed permanently beyond checking is evidence neither for nor against. TRAP: "God's ways are mysterious" is NOT skeptical theism. State CORNEA or Bergmann, or do not use the position at all.

ASCII MASTER FLOW – PANEL 13/22: Horrendous evils – balancing off versus defeat

MARILYN McCORD ADAMS, Horrendous Evils and the Goodness of God (1999)
PROMOTED TO CORE, 15 AUGUST 2026 – not an optional extra.

DEFINITION (technical): a HORRENDOUS EVIL is one whose participation – as PERPETRATOR or as VICTIM – gives the participant PRIMA FACIE reason to doubt whether their life could be A GREAT GOOD TO THEM ON THE WHOLE.

-> not a synonym for "very bad evil"; graphic detail is unnecessary.

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THE ARGUMENT

- (1) Standard theodicies work at the GLOBAL level, balancing evil within the world's total value.
- (2) But horrendous evils threaten the INDIVIDUAL'S LIFE AS A WHOLE: a global balance can be struck while a particular life remains, for that person, a net disaster.
- (3) A God who is good TO PERSONS – not merely a good PRODUCER OF WORLDS – must DEFEAT the evil WITHIN the frame of the individual's life.
- (4) Only resources internal to a particular religion – divine identification with human suffering, beatific intimacy as an INCOMMENSURABLE good – can accomplish that.

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THE DISTINCTION THAT EARNS THE MARKS

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BALANCING OFF	DEFEAT (Chisholm's term)	
the good OUTWEIGHS the evil	the evil becomes an ORGANIC PART of a	
in a sum; evil remains	whole whose value it CONTRIBUTES to;	
EXTERNAL to the good	evil is INTEGRATED, not offset	
+-----+-----+		
GLOBAL defeat (world level)	LOCAL / PERSONAL defeat (this life)	
what theodicies deliver	what Adams says is required	
+-----+-----+		

! COMPENSATION IS NOT DEFEAT. A later good can compensate for loss while leaving the evil externally balanced.

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OBJECTIONS AND REPLIES

! purely eschatological, unverifiable, seemingly instrumentalising

REPLY: Adams DENIES instrumentality – the evil need not be REQUIRED, only DEFEATED

! religion-specific resources abandon the neutral arena

REPLY: the atheological argument targets a PARTICULAR theism, so a particular theism may answer

INDIAN PARITY: karma explains DISTRIBUTION but not personal worth; Advaita's ultimate-level sublation and Buddhist liberation dissolve the standpoint from which the life is evaluated – critics call this evasive, defenders therapeutic.

CONTRAST TO NAME: DEFEAT WITHIN the life vs EXIT FROM the life-series.

ASCII MASTER FLOW – PANEL 14/22: Animal and pre-human suffering – the standing residue

THE ARGUMENT

- (1) Animal suffering PREDATES human moral agency.
 - (2) It cannot be the misuse of human free will.
 - (3) It cannot straightforwardly be the environment of MORAL growth for the sufferer.
 - (4) It cannot simply be called retributive.
 - (5) THEREFORE standard theodicies leave a MAJOR REMAINDER.
- Rowe's fawn is the evidential illustration, not a deductive contradiction.

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THE FIVE REPLIES, EACH WITH ITS COST

NEO-CARTESIAN	animals lack the higher-order awareness that makes pain MATTER morally (canvassed by MICHAEL MURRAY, Nature Red in Tooth and Claw, 2008) COST: philosophically and empirically contested
NOMIC REGULARITY	a stable law-governed world is needed to support any life at all COST: explains the KIND of world, not the AMOUNT
SOUL-MAKING EXTENDED	real danger is the only condition in which courage, compassion and stewardship TOWARD ANIMALS are possible COST: uses animals INSTRUMENTALLY
ESCHATOLOGICAL	animal fulfilment or redemption in a final state (minority line) COST: unverifiable and undeveloped
FALLEN-ORDER	a cosmic fall distorts nature prior to human history COST: ? historically and scientifically strained

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INDIAN PARITY

karma extends moral causation to ANIMAL BIRTHS (tiryak-yoni)
JAINISM ascribes living selves graded sense-capacity and grounds NON-INJURY (ahimsa)
BUDDHISM places animals within the same field of SUFFERING (dukkha) and extends COMPASSION (karuna) to sentient beings
COST is symmetrical to karma's general cost: unverifiable, and never to be used to infer that present suffering is deserved.
OBJECTION: an animal cannot LEARN from a fruit it cannot understand.
REPLY: karmic maturation is CAUSAL, not PEDAGOGICAL; the compassion it demands is unaffected by whether the animal grasps it.

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VERDICT: only NOMIC REGULARITY survives on the Western side, and it explains the KIND of world rather than the AMOUNT of pain in it; Indian karma answers the DISTRIBUTION question the West cannot, at the price of an unverifiable trans-life mechanism.

ASCII MASTER FLOW – PANEL 15/22: Process theodicy (2025 Q6(b), 15 marks) – the six tenets

SIX TENETS – "MAIN TENETS" IS AN ENUMERATION DIRECTIVE, SO NUMBER THEM

- (1) CREATIVITY, not God, is the ultimate; actual entities are self-creative occasions.
- (2) God is DIPOLAR:
 - PRIMORDIAL NATURE ordered envisagement of possibilities, supplying each occasion its INITIAL AIM
 - CONSEQUENT NATURE God's reception and preservation of what the world becomes
- (3) POWER IS INTRINSICALLY DISTRIBUTED: to be actual is to have some self-determination.
- (4) THEREFORE divine power is PERSUASIVE BY METAPHYSICAL NECESSITY (Griffin), NOT by self-limitation – the line that separates process theodicy from the free-will defence.
- (5) EVIL = finite occasions DEVIATING from the divine lure; God is not culpable.
- (6) God is "the FELLOW-SUFFERER WHO UNDERSTANDS" (Whitehead) – solidarity, not detachment.

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NAME THE LAYER – DO NOT WRITE "PROCESS THEODICY (WHITEHEAD)" AND STOP

WHITEHEAD Process and Reality (1929): dipolar God, initial aim, consequent nature, the fellow-sufferer

HARTSHORNE The Divine Relativity (1948); Omnipotence and Other Theological Mistakes (1984): classical omnipotence is INCOHERENT – to have ALL the power is to leave none to anything else; surrelativism/panentheism makes God supremely RELATED, not supremely UNAFFECTED

GRIFFIN God, Power, and Evil: A Process Theodicy (1976); Evil Revisited (1991): persuasion is a METAPHYSICAL NECESSITY, not a chosen restraint

COBB A Christian Natural Theology: the theological systematisation

IT IS A THEODICY, NOT A DEFENCE: it claims God's ACTUAL situation and is therefore refutable in a way Plantinga's defence is not.

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CRITICISM: a God who cannot guarantee victory over evil may be UNWORTHY OF WORSHIP; the metaphysics is contested; classical theists DENY that actuality entails self-determination. REPLY: divine solidarity, and the OBJECTIVE IMMORTALITY of achieved value in the consequent nature – but the objection does not disappear.

VERDICT: process theodicy purchases GOD'S INNOCENCE at the price of GOD'S SOVEREIGNTY.

ASCII MASTER FLOW – PANEL 16/22: The non-classical reply-space and its costs

THE REPLY-SPACE AROUND THE CLASSICAL THEODICIES – EVERY ENTRY IS PRICED

GREATER-GOOD / STABLE ORDER	risk and regular law are needed for freedom, agency, courage and compassion COST: explains the KIND of world, not the AMOUNT or the DISTRIBUTION of suffering
LEIBNIZIAN BEST WORLD	Theodicee (1710), which also gives the word "theodicy": a perfect God chooses the best total COMPOSSIBLE order, not a world containing every local good COST: there may be no unique best world, and world-total optimisation can neglect goodness to particular persons
ESCHATOLOGICAL FULFILMENT	no finite suffering is final; later fulfilment, restoration or union can prevent a life from being finally wasted COST: compensation after suffering is not automatically justification for permitting it
DIVINE MYSTERY	finite minds may fail to grasp providential reasons COST: unfalsifiable without an access principle;
PROTEST / ANTI-THEODICY	skeptical theism is the disciplined evidential version refusing to justify suffering protects truthfulness, lament and the moral priority of resistance COST: diagnoses the ETHICS of explanation but settles neither the logical nor the evidential argument

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THE REVISION STRATEGY IN GENERAL

weaken OMNIPOTENCE	-> process, finite God	goodness preserved
weaken PERSONALITY	-> impersonal Absolute, Advaita	evil at the empirical level only
remove CREATORSHIP	-> Buddhism, Jainism, Mimamsa	no defendant at all

EVERY revision purchases relief with a RELIGIOUSLY SIGNIFICANT LOSS.
Naming the loss is what converts description into evaluation.

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! COMPENSATION IS NOT DEFEAT. Pastoral responsibility requires listening, protection and action BEFORE speculative explanation; a theodicy never licenses passivity toward preventable harm.

ASCII MASTER FLOW – PANEL 17/22: The Indian response – karma and the schools

WESTERN QUESTION: why does a good God PERMIT evil?

INDIAN QUESTION : how does BONDAGE ORIGINATE, and how is it ENDED?

KARMA-SAMSARA: suffering is the fruit of one's own past deeds across lives; the moral law is SELF-OPERATING. Evil therefore raises no problem for a creator's goodness – it is COSMIC JUSTICE, not divine cruelty.

THE SCHOOLS DIFFER – KARMA IS NOT ONE DOCTRINE

NON-THEISTIC	Buddhism · Jainism · Mimamsa	no divine distributor required -> THERE IS NO DEFENDANT
THEISTIC	Nyaya · Ramanuja	God dispenses karmic fruit JUSTLY as karma-superintendent (karmadhyaksa): a JUDGE, not an arbitrary cause of evil
ADVAITA	evil is real at the EMPIRICAL level (vyavaharika) and sublated under liberating knowledge at the ULTIMATE level (paramarthika); Brahman is untouched. COST: risk of minimising present suffering	

BEGINNINGLESSNESS: the action-consequence series is treated as BEGINNINGLESS, so no first wrongful act need be identified. It blocks ONE regress question and VERIFIES NOTHING about any claimed past-life cause.

MORAL CONTROLS – NON-NEGOTIABLE

! the inference from "this person suffers" to "this person deserves it for a specific past act" is UNAVAILABLE to ordinary observers; using karma that way converts explanation into VICTIM-BLAMING

! natural suffering, collective harms and unequal starting conditions still press the fairness and verification of the mechanism

! karma does not cancel present duties of COMPASSION, PROTECTION and RELIEF

BOUNDARY: personal identity, rebirth mechanics and the metaphysics of liberation belong to Soul, Immortality, Rebirth and Liberation.

ASCII MASTER FLOW – PANEL 18/22: The India-West parity bench

WHAT THE EXAMINER IS REALLY ASKING, AND WHO CAN ANSWER IT

QUESTION	WESTERN RESOURCE	INDIAN RESOURCE
why evil at all?	free will · privation · soul-making	ignorance (avidya) · inflow (asrava) · craving (tanha)
why THIS person?	! weak – no standard answer	karma across lives
why so MUCH?	nomic regularity · skeptical theism	beginningless samsara – no first excess to justify
is God culpable?	theodicies · process denial of coercive power	Nyaya: allots PER karma; non-theistic schools: no defendant at all
what defeats evil for the sufferer?	Adams' beatific intimacy · eschatology	liberation (moksa/nirvana/kaivalya) as ending the standpoint of suffering
animal suffering	nomic regularity · neo-Cartesian	animal births (tiryak-yoni) · graded Jain jiva · ahimsa · karuna

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WHERE THEY DIVERGE

the West asks about PERMISSION; India about the ORIGINATION OF BONDAGE

the distribution question is India's STRUCTURAL ADVANTAGE

the West must justify a QUANTITY; India denies the frame by beginninglessness

India can DROP THE DEFENDANT; the West cannot

DEFEAT WITHIN the life (Adams) vs EXIT FROM the life-series (moksa/nirvana)

India MORALISES animal suffering; the West mostly BRACKETS it

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EPISTEMIC PARITY WITH SKEPTICAL THEISM

unseen moral potency (adrsta) is BEYOND THE SENSES (atindriya), known only through testimony (sabda); the precise ripening of karma is among the Buddhist IMPONDERABLES (acinteyya). The parallel is genuine and inherits the SAME objection: a mechanism placed permanently beyond checking is evidence NEITHER FOR NOR AGAINST.

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ANSWER LINE: India's structural advantage is not that it explains evil better but that it answers a DIFFERENT QUESTION – not why evil is permitted, but why THIS person suffers – and it can drop the defendant altogether.

ASCII MASTER FLOW – PANEL 19/22: Evil and the profane – the three theorists and the sequence

2019 Q6(b), 15 marks. THIS IS A FUNCTIONAL, NOT A THEOLOGICAL, QUESTION.

It does not ask whether evil disproves God. It asks what evil and the profane DO.

THE THREE CANONICAL THEORISTS – DO NOT INTERCHANGE THEM

DURKHEIM The Elementary Forms of Religious Life (1912) – SOCIAL SIDE

all known religious beliefs presuppose a classification of all things into two opposed classes, PROFANE and SACRED; religion = a unified system of beliefs and practices RELATIVE TO SACRED THINGS, uniting adherents into a single moral community, a CHURCH. The definition is deliberately GOD-FREE.

OTTO The Idea of the Holy (1917) – OBJECT SIDE

the sacred is an A PRIORI category of response: the NUMINOUS, mysterium tremendum et fascinans

ELIADE The Sacred and the Profane (1957) – SPATIAL / TEMPORAL

the sacred irrupts as HIEROPHANY, generating sacred SPACE (a fixed centre, AXIS MUNDI, against homogeneous profane extension) and sacred TIME (recoverable and repeatable, against irreversible profane duration)

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THE FOUR-STEP FOUNDING SEQUENCE

(1) PREDICAMENT something is wrong: sin · impurity · suffering (duhkha) · ignorance (avidya) · karmic bondage · alienation

(2) BOUNDARY pure/impure · sacred/profane · saved/lost -> ritual, prohibition, code

(3) INSTITUTION priesthood · initiation · purification · penance · community discipline

(4) SOTERIOLOGY the ordered path OUT

=> evil and the profane are not embarrassments TO religion but part of its STRUCTURAL

FOUNDATION: without a diagnosis of what is wrong, salvation-language has no work to do.

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FOUR CATEGORIES THAT MUST NOT BE MERGED

EVIL = moral or natural harm | PROFANE = the ORDINARY, the non-consecrated

IMPURE = the ritually polluting | DEMONIC = the actively anti-sacred

! DURKHEIM'S PROFANE IS NOT EVIL. A ploughed field, a market and a weekday are profane and none of them is wicked. Conflating them is the commonest error on this stem.

ASCII MASTER FLOW – PANEL 20/22: Evil and the profane – Indian parity, objections and verdict

INDIAN PARITY (MANDATORY)

BUDDHISM the FIRST NOBLE TRUTH makes suffering (dukkha) the explicit foundation of an entire religion – the clearest world case of evil AS religion-founding

JAINISM inflow (asrava) and bondage (bandha) name the predicament; stoppage (samvara) and shedding (nirjara) name the exit

ADVAITA ignorance (avidya) is the founding defect; liberating knowledge is the exit

BRAHMANICAL purity and impurity (suddhi/asuddhi) and cleanliness (sauca) organise

RITUAL practice; auspicious/inauspicious (mangala/amangala); demerit and merit (papa/punya)

MIMAMSA ritual purity codes; correct performance is the rectification

! RIDER: India's founding defect is more often IGNORANCE or BONDAGE than MORAL EVIL – diagnosis-and-insight rather than sin-and-forgiveness. This changes the SHAPE of the resulting religion and is the highest-value comparative sentence in the answer.

PRESUPPOSITION: that religion can be defined FUNCTIONALLY by structure rather than SUBSTANTIVELY by its object; and that the sacred/profane binary is genuinely cross-cultural.

OBJECTIONS AND REPLIES

! the binary is a Durkheimian imposition; many traditions GRADE rather than dichotomise; Eliade's universal archaic ontology is unfalsifiable

REPLY: treat the pair as an IDEAL TYPE that organises comparison, not as a law

! founding religion on evil makes religion PARASITIC on suffering, so a world without suffering would be a world without religion

REPLY: worship, wonder and gratitude are INDEPENDENT religious roots; the sacred is not exhausted by the negative pole

VERDICT: evil and the profane found religion STRUCTURALLY RATHER THAN DOCTRINALLY – they supply the predicament, the boundary and the soteriological task without which religious practice would be unintelligible. But they found RELIGION, NOT THEISM, which is why the same analysis covers Buddhism and Jainism and leaves the theistic problem of evil entirely untouched.

OWNERSHIP: this file owns the EVIL/PROFANE pole; the SACRED/HOLY-AS-OBJECT pole belongs to Religious Experience (2018 Q7(a)). The questions differ: here the category is RELIGION-FOUNDING, there it is OBJECT-IDENTIFYING.

ASCII MASTER FLOW – PANEL 21/22: Concept-dependence and the assessment grid

RUN THE CLASSICAL SET AGAINST FOUR GOD-CONCEPTS (2024 Q6(c), 15 marks)

GOD-CONCEPT	EFFECT ON THE PROBLEM	RELIGIOUSLY SIGNIFICANT LOSS
classical theism	FULL FORCE, all burdens live	nothing yet; theodicies must work
finite / process God	DISSOLVED at the logical level	sovereignty; any guarantee of final victory over evil
impersonal Absolute (Advaita, nirguna)	RELOCATED: evil real at the empirical level, sublated at the ultimate level	a personal God to address; risk of minimising suffering
no creator (Buddhism, Jainism, Mimamsa)	REMOVED: no defendant; conditions and deeds explain	providence, divine rescue, a cosmic guarantor of justice

! CONCEPT-DEPENDENCE IS NOT A SOLUTION. It relocates the cost from the ARGUMENT into the THEOLOGY. The theodicies exist precisely to KEEP ALL THE ATTRIBUTES.

THE ASSESSMENT GRID

THEODICY	EXPLAINS	PRESERVES	WEAKNESS
free-will	moral	omnipotence + goodness	natural evil left over
Augustinian privation	moral via Fall	all attributes	privation strained; innocence and animals
soul-making (Hick) process	moral + natural all	purposive goodness, NOT omnipotence	scale; animals; eschatology sacrifices classical omnipotence
karma	all + DISTRIBUTION	cosmic justice; no creator-blame	victim-blaming; verification; regress
Advaita	empirical evil	Brahman untouched	minimising suffering
skeptical theism	none (defence)	all attributes	moral scepticism; unfalsifiability

FOUR STANDING CRITICISMS – REPLY AND REJOINDER

EXCESS EVIL	reply: epistemic limits, long-range goods rejoinder: unknown reasons cannot become a blanket licence
NATURAL EVIL	reply: stable natural law enables agency rejoinder: stability does not explain every extreme distribution
DIVINE RESPONSIBILITY	reply: foreknowledge does not cause free action rejoinder: knowingly choosing the whole system remains relevant
KARMA AND COMPASSION	reply: classical ethics requires compassion regardless of cause; explanatory karma does not authorise social judgement

ASCII MASTER FLOW – PANEL 22/22: The answer route and the qualified conclusion

THE UNIVERSAL SPINE – USE AT EVERY MARK LEVEL

- (1) NAME the version: logical | evidential | existential | horrendous | animal | distributional
- (2) STATE the set WITH ITS BRIDGES, or the probability judgement with its inductive step
- (3) RECONSTRUCT the reply as NUMBERED PREMISES, correctly attributed
- (4) OBJECT and REPLY, then state the RESIDUE
- (5) COMPARE with one deliberate Indian or Western comparator that does argumentative work
- (6) GRADE: what it explains · what it preserves · what it COSTS · what it leaves untouched

DIRECTIVE DECODER – WHAT EACH PRINTED STEM BUYS

"What is the logical problem of evil? Discuss"	the SET and its BRIDGING PREMISES	2020
"Discuss the paradox of..."	a dilemma: horn, cost, horn, cost, then the dissolving restriction	2021
"Critically examine [a quoted thesis]"	fidelity to the claim's SCOPE first	2022
"'Quotation.' Critically discuss"	reconstruct the author's system, THEN test it	2023
"Direct offshoot of how God is conceptualised"	show the DEPENDENCE by varying the God-concept, then price it	2024
"Explain the main tenets of X"	ENUMERATED doctrine, correctly attributed; number the tenets	2025
"What role do A and B play to found..."	a FUNCTIONAL account: predicament -> boundary -> institution -> soteriology	2019

BANDS: 10m ~150 words | 15m ~240-260 words | 20m ~340-360 words

VERDICT LADDER

- ~40% asserts the triad; no version identified
- ~50% distinguishes logical from evidential; two theodicies listed
- ~60% bridges stated; one theodicy fully reconstructed; Indian comparator present
- ~65-70% version-matched theodicy; objection with reply; distribution raised; costs stated
- ~70%+ adds defeat-vs-balancing-off, or CORNEA, or the animal-suffering gap – AND an explicit statement of what the theist has GIVEN UP to survive

NEVER END DEVOTIONALLY. "God's purposes are ultimately good" is not a verdict.

QUALIFIED CONCLUSION: the problem of evil is a stress-test of a PARTICULAR God-concept, not of religion as such. Weaken omnipotence, weaken personality, or remove the creator and it dissolves – but every dissolution purchases relief with a religiously significant loss, and every surviving theodicy is priced. A theodicy is not refuted by its cost; it is MEASURED by it, and the answer's final task is to state that price.